

The Mattering Kit

FIRST EDITION, FOR PRACTITIONER REVIEW, 2026

Young people who feel they do not matter are the ones extremist groups look for first. What those groups offer is rarely ideology. It is belonging, and the sense of being significant to someone. This kit collects what the research literature suggests adults in schools can do about that, in the time and with the resources they already have.

This is not a programme and it has not been tested. It is my own reading of the literature, as a student, written for the people who do this work every day. I am sending it around for review, and it will change based on the feedback.

Start here: the invisibility audit

This is the most important part of the kit. It takes about five minutes, and it gives you an understanding of your class that you do not already have.

Write down every student in your class. Next to each name, mark whether there is at least one adult in this building who knows that child as a person, beyond their name and their grades. Not just who teaches them, but who actually knows them.

Then circle every name without a mark.

	STUDENT	ADULT WHO KNOWS THEM
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		
13		
14		
15		

	STUDENT	ADULT WHO KNOWS THEM
16		
17		
18		
19		
20		
21		
22		
23		
24		
25		
26		
27		
28		
29		
30		

CAUTION Do not tell a child they are on this list. Being identified as the “at-risk case” is itself an injury to a child’s sense of mattering, and it might do more harm than good. The circled names are for you, and for the colleagues you work with.

Four practices

START WITH THE NAMES YOU CIRCLED

1

Greet every student by name at the door

Stand at the entrance and greet each student individually as they come in. It costs a few minutes at the start of a lesson. It targets the most basic component of mattering, which is being noticed at all.

2

Give every student something the class depends on

A real task, assigned daily or weekly, that someone would notice if it went undone. Being needed is a distinct component of mattering, and it is the one the students in your class are most likely to be missing.

3

Two minutes a day for ten days

Pick the student you find hardest to reach and talk to them for two minutes a day, about anything other than school, for ten consecutive days. Widely used by teachers and often reported as effective, though the formal evidence is limited.

4

Pair students who never work together

Structure tasks so that students cooperate across the walls they have drawn. Research on intergroup contact and on cooperative learning supports this, though the effects depend heavily on the conditions being right: cooperation rather than proximity, equal status, and visible support from the adult.

What this does not do

None of these practices has been shown to reduce extremist recruitment, and this kit does not claim that. They target the need that recruiters might exploit.

Nothing here should be used as a substitute for changing how the school actually treats a child.

Feedback

This draft exists to be corrected. If you have used any of this, or think any of it is wrong, please let me know at jragogna@macalester.edu or fill out this [feedback form](#).